

English
Book Two
For the class XII

The Age of Infancy

by

Dr. Allama Muhammad Iqbal

About the Author



Name	Allama Iqbal
Born & died	November 9, 1877 , April 21, 1938
Place of birth	Sialkot
Profession	A poet, philosopher, and lawyer
Literary period	the Modern Period of Urdu literature— specifically, the Early Modern or Progressive Era (late 19th to early 20th century).
Achievements	Philosopher-Poet of the East: Author of Influential Works: • <i>Bang-e-Dra</i> (The Call of the Marching Bell) • <i>Asrar-e-Khudi</i> (Secrets of the Self) • <i>Rumuz-e-Bekhudi</i> (Mysteries of Selflessness) • <i>Payam-e-Mashriq</i> (Message of the East) • <i>Bal-e-Jibril</i> and <i>Zarb-e-Kalim</i> • Concept of “Khudi” (Selfhood) • Ideological Founder of Pakistan Political Contributions: • Member of the Punjab Legislative Council (1927–1930) • President of the All-India Muslim League (1930) Recognition and Honors: • Titled “Sir” by the British Government in 1922 for his scholarly and literary contributions. • Celebrated as National Poet of Pakistan :

The Poem

Type of works	Philosophical and symbolic poem
Written	between 1901 and 1905
Published	<i>Bang-e-Dra</i> (1924)
Main Theme(s)	“The Age of Infancy” reflects on the purity, innocence, and freedom of childhood. Iqbal compares childhood to a blessed stage of life untouched by greed, hypocrisy, or the burdens of adulthood. • It symbolizes a state of natural harmony with God and nature. • He implies that as humans grow, they lose the spiritual purity they once had as children.

Short Question Answers

Q. No-1 How does Dr. Allama Muhammad Iqbal depict the theme of innocence and simplicity in the poem *The Age of Infancy*?

Ans. In the poem "*The Age of Infancy*", Dr. Allama Muhammad Iqbal beautifully presents the theme of innocence and simplicity through a child's pure and carefree world. He recalls how everything seemed new, peaceful, and full of wonders. The child finds comfort in small things, joy in nature, and curiosity about the moon and sky. Iqbal shows that childhood is a stage of purity and closeness to nature and God, untouched by greed, fear, or worldly desires.

Q. No- 2 What role does curiosity play in the poem, and how does it shape the speaker's experience of the world?

Ans. In *The poem*, curiosity plays a central role in shaping the speaker's view of the world. Iqbal shows how a child's heart is full of questions and wonder. The child looks at the moon, the sky, and nature with deep interest, trying to understand their mysteries. This curiosity gives meaning to every small thing around him and becomes the source of his joy and discovery. It reflects the purity of a child's mind, eager to learn, imagine, and explore life without fear or limits.

Q. No- 3. How does the poem evoke feelings of nostalgia for infancy?

Ans. Allama Iqbal creates a strong sense of nostalgia by recalling the peaceful and joyful days of childhood. He remembers a time when life was simple, and even small things like the sound of a door chain or the sight of the moon brought happiness. The poet contrasts that innocent past with the worries of adult life, making the reader long for the same purity and comfort. Through gentle memories and vivid images, Iqbal expresses deep affection for his lost childhood days.

Q. No- 4. What can be inferred about the speaker's understanding of the world during infancy from the line "The earth and sky were unknown worlds to me"?

Ans. From the line "*The earth and sky were unknown worlds to me,*" we can infer that the speaker's understanding of the world during infancy was very limited but filled with wonders. Everything around him was new, mysterious, and beyond his comprehension. The vastness of the earth and sky made him curious but also innocent, as he could only see beauty, not complexity. This line shows the child's pure and unknowing mind, which sees the world not through logic or knowledge but through amazement and imagination.

Q. No- 5 How does the metaphor "My heart was no less than inquisitiveness personified" shape the reader's understanding of the speaker's emotional state? Elaborate.

Ans. the metaphor “*My heart was no less than inquisitiveness personified*” shows that the speaker’s heart was full of curiosity and wonder. It means his desire to know and explore was so strong that curiosity itself seemed alive within him. This helps the reader understand that the speaker’s emotional state was active, eager, and deeply engaged with the world around him. The line beautifully captures the restless energy of childhood — a time when every sight, sound, and mystery inspired excitement, questions, and joyful discovery.

Meanings and synonyms from the poem *The Age of Infancy*:

Word	Meaning (in simple English)	Synonyms
Bosom	The heart or inner feelings; a place of comfort and peace / the seat of emotions.	Heart, soul, chest, core
Devoted	Showing deep love, loyalty, or dedication.	Faithful, loyal, committed, dedicated
Expanse	A wide, open area; something that stretches far.	Stretch, spread, area, space
Infancy	The early stage of life or development; childhood.	Babyhood, childhood, youth, beginning
Inquisitiveness	Eager desire to learn or know; curiosity.	Curiosity, interest, eagerness, questioning
Personified	Represented as having human qualities or form.	Embodied, symbolized, represented, exemplified
Prone	Likely or inclined to do something; lying face downward.	Likely, inclined, susceptible, apt
Prudent Lie	A lie told wisely or carefully to avoid harm or trouble.	Wise deceit, careful falsehood, diplomatic lie

Figurative Meanings

1. Moon

Literal meaning: The bright celestial body visible at night.

Figurative meaning:

- Symbol of **wonder, beauty, life, and innocence** in a child’s imagination.
- Represents the **unknown mysteries of the universe** that attract a child’s curiosity.

- It also reflects the **light of truth** that the child seeks but does not fully understand.

2. Broken Clouds

Literal meaning: Scattered clouds partly covering the moon.

Figurative meaning:

- Symbol of **obstacles and uncertainties** that partly hide reality.
- Represents the **incomplete understanding** a child has about the vast world.
- It shows that even though truth (the moon) exists, it is not fully clear to the immature mind.

3. Door Chain

Literal meaning: The chain on a door that makes a sound when moved.

Figurative meaning:

- Symbol of **comfort and security** — the child feels safe in familiar surroundings.
- Represents the **simple things** that bring peace to an innocent heart.
- It may also hint at the **bond between mother and child**, where even a small household sound soothes him.

4. Silent Journey

Literal meaning: The moon's quiet movement through the sky.

Figurative meaning:

- Symbol of **life's calm and continuous passage**.
- Represents the **mystery of time and creation** that silently unfolds.
- It also reflects the **spiritual stillness** that fascinates a pure, questioning soul.

5. Prudent Lie

Literal meaning: A wise or harmless lie told to satisfy a child's curiosity (e.g., about the moon).

Figurative meaning:

- Symbol of **the limits of human knowledge** — adults themselves lack real answers but comfort the child with gentle explanations.
- Represents the **gap between innocence and experience**, or **imagination and reality**.

It may also hint at the **protective illusion** that preserves a child's peace of mind.

6. Inquisitiveness Personified

Literal meaning: Curiosity turned into a living form.

Figurative meaning:

- Symbol of **the pure spirit of discovery** that defines childhood.
- Represents **human nature's thirst for knowledge** and truth.
- Iqbal uses it to show that the child is not just curious — he *is curiosity itself*, a living symbol of exploration.

Literary Devices:

1. Imagery

Definition: Using words to create vivid pictures that appeal to the senses.

Example: “*The earth and the sky were unknown worlds to me*”

Explanation: The poet creates a visual image of a child seeing the vastness of the earth and sky with wonder.

2. Symbolism

Definition: Using objects or elements to represent deeper meanings.

Examples:

- *Moon* → symbolizes mystery, beauty, and the curiosity of childhood.
- *Door chain* → symbolizes comfort and security.

- *Broken clouds* → symbolize the partial understanding of reality.

Explanation: Iqbal uses common images to express abstract ideas about innocence, safety, and limited human knowledge.

• 3. Personification

- **Definition:** Giving human qualities to non-living things or ideas.

Example: “*The moon's silent journey among broken clouds*”

Explanation: The moon is described as if it is quietly traveling, giving it a human-like quality.

• 4. Metaphor

- **Definition:** An indirect comparison between two unlike things.

Example: “*My heart was no less than inquisitiveness personified.*”

Explanation: The poet compares his heart to pure curiosity itself — not using “like” or “as,” but implying they are one.

• 5. Repetition

- **Definition:** Repeating words or ideas for emphasis.

Example: “*I would ask repeatedly about its mountains and plains.*”

Explanation: The repetition shows the endless curiosity and questioning nature of a child.

- **8. Tone**
- **Definition:** The poet's attitude or feeling in the poem.
Example: The tone is **nostalgic and reflective**.
Explanation: Iqbal recalls his childhood with warmth and longing for lost innocence.

10 multiple-choice questions (MCQs) from the poem “*The Age of Infancy*,” by Dr. Allama Muhammad Iqbal.

1.

What is the main theme of the poem *The Age of Infancy*?

- A) The pain of adulthood
- B) The joy and innocence of childhood
- C) The struggle for freedom
- D) The importance of education

2.

In the poem, what does the “mother’s bosom” symbolize?

- A) The entire world of a child
- B) The hardship of life
- C) The beauty of nature
- D) The limits of human knowledge

3.

What feeling does the poet express when he recalls his infancy?

- A) Anger
- B) Regret
- C) Nostalgia
- D) Fear

4.

Which natural object becomes a source of wonder for the child in the poem?

- A) The sun
- B) The moon
- C) The river
- D) The tree

5.

What does the sound of the door chain represent in the poem?

- A) A call to adventure

- B) A source of fear
- C) A symbol of comfort and safety
- D) A reminder of loneliness

6.

How does the poet describe the child's curiosity?

- A) As endless and pure
- B) As foolish and meaningless
- C) As selfish and stubborn
- D) As calm and silent

7.

The phrase "*silent journey among broken clouds*" mainly creates an image of:

- A) The moon's quiet movement
- B) The stormy night
- C) The darkness of the sky
- D) The peace after rain

8.

Why does the child believe in the "prudent lie" told to him?

- A) Because he is afraid of the truth
- B) Because his imagination is innocent and trusting
- C) Because he dislikes asking questions
- D) Because he understands the adults' wisdom

9.

What emotion dominates the tone of the poem?

- A) Joyful excitement
- B) Fear and confusion
- C) Gentle longing and reflection
- D) Anger and sadness

10.

What quality of childhood does Iqbal highlight through this poem?

- A) Ambition and competition
- B) Purity, faith, and wonder
- C) Logic and intelligence
- D) Knowledge and power

Answer key with justifications:

1.

Answer: B) The joy and innocence of childhood

Explanation: The poem celebrates the purity, peace, and happiness of a child's early life, free from worldly worries.

2.

Answer: A) The entire world of a child

Explanation: For the infant, the mother's arms are the whole world — a place of warmth, care, and safety.

3.

Answer: C) Nostalgia

Explanation: The poet fondly remembers his childhood with longing for its innocence and simplicity.

4.

Answer: B) The moon

Explanation: The poet describes his fascination with the moon, symbolizing a child's curiosity about nature and the universe.

5.

Answer: C) A symbol of comfort and safety

Explanation: The sound of the door chain soothes the crying child, showing his sense of peace in familiar surroundings.

6.

Answer: A) As endless and pure

Explanation: The poet portrays childhood curiosity as innocent and full of wonder — the heart of discovery.

7.

Answer: A) The moon's quiet movement

Explanation: The phrase describes the moon's calm, silent passage through the clouds, symbolizing peace and mystery.

8.

Answer: B) Because his imagination is innocent and trusting

Explanation: The child believes harmless lies due to his pure and trusting nature, not yet touched by doubt.

9.

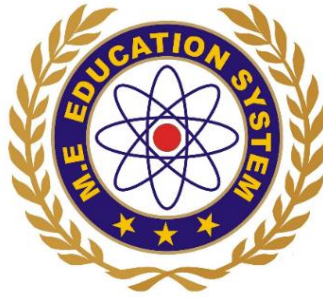
Answer: C) Gentle longing and reflection

Explanation: The tone is soft and reflective, expressing a tender yearning for the lost innocence of childhood.

10.

Answer: B) Purity, faith, and wonder

Explanation: Iqbal highlights the spiritual and emotional purity of childhood — a time of faith, curiosity, and harmony with nature.



A rich tribute to great Iqbal:

خدا نے آج تک اس قوم کی حالت نہیں بدلی
نہ ہو جس کو خیال آپ اپنی حالت کے بدلنے کا

Transliteration:

*Khuda ne aaj tak us qaum ki halat nahi badli,
Na ho jisko khayal aap apni halat ke badalne ka.*

Translation:

*God never changes the condition of a nation,
Until it strives to change its own condition.*

Meaning:

Iqbal teaches **self-responsibility** — progress begins when people take initiative instead of waiting for miracles.